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Phil Flanigan

Phil Flanigan is one of the most in-demand bassists in jazz today. A native of Geneva, New York, he found fertile playing ground in Providence with tenor saxophonist Scott Hamilton. With guitarist Chris Flory and drummer Chuck Riggs, a working quartet evolved that eventually recorded over twenty albums and helped renew interest in mainstream jazz. In New York, Phil performed and recorded with a long list of jazz veterans including Bob Wilber, Benny Goodman, Mel Torme and Maxine Sullivan. His passion is preserving the acoustic quality of the bass in jazz and he has demonstrated that conviction on over fifty recordings to date. Phil travels from his home in Florida to appear at festivals and jazz parties here and abroad. His most recent solo release is entitled "New York Toast" and features his original compositions for quartet.

Phil was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 15, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in San Diego, California at the San Diego Jazz Party and it's a real pleasure to have bassist Phil Flanigan with me, one of the fine upstate New York jazz musicians on the scene today. But you're one of the few whose name does not end with a vowel you know.

PF: Well that depends on how many other upstate musicians you're aware of.

MR: Well why don't you fill me in, because there's probably all sorts that I don't know about.

PF: Well the immediate few that come to mind are my contemporaries in Geneva, in years probably '72 to '74, Michael Hashim, the alto saxophonist, and Chris Flory the guitarist, also with Scott Hamilton. His original home is Geneva also. And a drummer by the name of John Ellis in New York. Those are just Genevans. And I've become more aware of other upstaters like Mel Lewis and Lonnie Smith the organist — they're Buffalo guys. and then of course all the other Italian upstate guys, the Joe Romanos and the Scott LaFaros.

MR: Right. Did you get into Rochester much as a kid, fairly close, to hear any music in there? You wound up going to Eastman, right?

PF: I heard Monk at U of R.

MR: No kidding.

PF: Yeah. That's the only time I saw Monk, and it's the only time I saw a concert at U of R. I thought it was great. I think it was probably 1972 or something like that, or maybe a tad earlier. But I can at least say I saw Monk. I mean there's a lot of other guys, having been born when I was, that I never did get a chance to see.

MR: Yeah. What drew you to jazz and the string bass? I mean you could have been attracted to

PF: Well, which part of that do you want me to answer?

MR: That was a long question, wasn't it?

PF: No, I got it. Basically I always liked bass — that sounds poetic, doesn't it? Like every other thirteen year old in 1969, I took up the guitar, because I wanted to be another Pete Townshend or Jimi Hendrix. Well that didn't last long luckily because my dad has a very good jazz collection and hung out with Bird a few times and that kind of a thing. So he has a comprehensive Charlie Parker collection, a very good collection of Lester Young and Benny Goodman and Basie and Ellington and on down the line. And I always heard that music growing up, but when you're thirteen it doesn't seem all that important. It's just environmental. It wasn't chosen. So the music I was exposed to with my peers and whatnot in the late '60s, all the Hendrix and rock and Beatles and whatever else, that was a phase I went through with the guitar, but I found I was still playing bass lines on the guitar when I'd get together with a couple of friends who were guitar players, they'd play guitar stuff and I'd play bass stuff. So I eventually got an electric bass, and that didn't last long, and I found a cheap upright, and my dad bought it for me, it was only a hundred seventy-five bucks, which was ridiculous by these days.

MR: Like a set of strings now, right?

PF: Less, less. To get good gut strings it's almost three hundred dollars a set. Anyway, so that phase of my musical career didn't last long luckily because I discovered that I actually liked — there was a period when I was about fifteen or sixteen where I got interested in my dad's collection as my musical awareness sort of expanded a bit from listening to other things, and I discovered Monk records — of course I'd known who these people were my whole life, but I didn't like make my own research into it until I was in my mid upper teens. And then it became mine, not just my dad's. Then I embraced it.

MR: Was your father a musician, an amateur at all?

PF: Yeah. He used to play. He played with the Mangiones at different times — not regularly, just on a couple of occasions.

MR: On what instrument?

PF: Clarinet, alto and tenor. And he worked with a bunch of guys around Geneva, around that Geneva, Canandaigua and Sampson Air Force Base, in the '50s when it was going, in a place called the Club 86 and the Holiday Bar and Grill in downtown Geneva. Club 86 had a lot of people through there: Coleman Hawkins, Dizzy and a bunch of people throughout the years. And I'll mention to an older musician who I'll meet from time to time, did you ever play a place called Club 86? And they go yeah, upstate New York, right? Yeah, it seemed to be on the circuit there for a while. So my dad's connected with that upstate jazz scene of which there are others, like Wayne Andre, the trombonist, went

they would go into Geneva and have parties and jam sessions and whatnot. But obviously the biggest jazz name out of my home town was Scott LaFaro. And I guess this isn't really answering your question too good.

MR: That's right I forgot he came from there.

PF: I'm sort of getting off into—

MR: It's okay.

PF: Well I played guitar and then I got interested in bass, I got interested in jazz.

MR: And then the music came.

PF: And then my dad told me about Scott LaFaro, who he knew very well, having come from Geneva, Scott. And he showed me the newspaper article, the cover page on the *Geneva Times* from 1961, July 6, 1961 where LaFaro is on the cover, with his crashed car and the whole bit.

MR: Where did that happen?

PF: Flint, New York, just between 5 and 20, between Geneva and Canandaigua. And the tree — I was just there a few months ago — the tree is still there, scarred, sitting in front of this little house. My first lesson I drove by it, knowing what it was.

MR: He just like—

PF: He'd been up all night, he worked the night with Stan Getz in I believe it was either Newport or Lake Placid. I think he had the gig in Newport, which there's recorded evidence with Stan Getz. I haven't heard it — all you people out there, I'd like to hear it — and he either stayed up and drove to Geneva or there was another gig the night after that and then he stayed up all night and drove to Geneva. My dad saw him, blah, blah, blah, didn't accompany him that night.

MR: Well he was quite a pioneer of a sorts on the bass, and his work, did it affect your own playing?

PF: Well yeah. I mean I discovered his playing through Hampton Hawes records and Ornette Coleman records and of course the Bill Evans stuff, not to mention a bunch of others. But I thought, wow, that's a different approach and I really like that. And then I found out my close connection with him, and I was sort of shocked. I mean here I am going to high school, trying to learn how to wail on the bass, and then finding out that this pioneer cat, I'm walking the same hallowed halls and this kind of thing. I used to visit his grave all the time, yeah. I probably saw him, I probably laid eyes on him, but he died when I was five, so I don't recall. It's possible.

MR: Plus he probably wasn't carrying a bass down the street.

PF: No, he was probably just hanging out.

MR: Just a guy.

MR: You ended up at Eastman?

PF: Well I did go to Eastman in the prep program.

MR: For a while.

PF: In that program I just had theory class and lessons, two hours every Saturday, so that was for two years. So I probably went there a hundred times — well no, school year is probably less than that, probably eighty times or something for lessons. I had lessons with Oscar Zimmerman, the principal bassist for the Rochester Philharmonic and also the teacher of Ron Carter among others. I think me and Ron are the only ones really—

MR: Still out there doing it.

PF: Right.

MR: Did you have any desire to go to Eastman?

PF: Well to get musical education however I could get it, sure. Absolutely. But Zimmerman was the cat. He was the cat to go to if you were going to take bass lessons. I'm sorry, go ahead.

MR: Well you ended up, what was the first big gig for you?

PF: The first big gig.

MR: Yeah. I mean you know, playing with big people, you know, like 280 pounds or something. Never mind, sorry, bad joke.

PF: Well that's tough. I remember one time in Boston when I was going to school I did a gig with Tiny Grimes that got televised, and that was funny, because a friend of mine broke a table laughing so hard when he watched it at home.

MR: Why was it so funny?

PF: I don't know it was just one of those college things you know, your buddy's on TV playing with this old guitar player that used to play with Art Tatum. I don't know, they thought it was funny. I probably did look pretty funny.

MR: And you moved to the Boston area and got re-hooked-up with Chris Flory?

PF: Well that's a little bit more complicated than that. I went to Boston for a year. Chris had gone to Providence because he already knew Scott Hamilton from high school. Chris spent some time in Providence and then New York City and then Geneva again, this was all after his childhood in Geneva. And then I hooked up back with him in Providence after my year in Boston. Because the school wasn't really cutting it for me. I wasn't learning what I wanted to learn, which was authentic, trial by fire, empirical evidence, sort of nightly gained on the bandstand type of jazz experience. That's what I was looking for. And obviously school is not set up to do that. And I had this chance to go down and jam and play with Scott Hamilton, who we already knew, I mean he was the only guy our age. He was the same type of creature as we were. We were viewed as

reactionaries and elitists by our peers and contemporaries, for being swing snobs or whatever.

MR: No kidding.

PF: Yeah, sure.

MR: Because they were into what? Contemporary?

PF: More eclectic, or, I don't know just less quality as far as I'm concerned. It's hard to describe exactly what I mean.

MR: Were they more into, what, playing modal jazz or Coltrane?

PF: Yeah, maybe some of that, and some more pop forms.

MR: And this was what year?

PF: This would have been '75 I guess. So I went down to Providence and hung out on the scene with Hamilton a lot. Chris Flory had a quartet, because Scott already had his own band, with a great guitar player by the name of Fred Bates. And with Chuck Riggs as well, who followed him on into New York and everything. And we were sort of the two straight ahead or swing and bebop based jazz bands in Providence, so whatever gigs there were, you know Scott would get all the good ones and we'd sort of pick up the crumbs. But then they had a major personnel shift toward the end of my days in Providence, they had a big shake-up with Roomful of Blues with Duke Robillard on guitar, and Preston Hubbard, well actually that's the story. I was living with Roomful's baritone player, Doug Schlect, and there was all this rumbling in the band about personnel changes and stuff, and they wanted to get rid of their bass player and they wanted an upright and all this kind of stuff. So there was talk of me joining Roomful of Blues. So I got all the records that Duke told me to get, all the T-Bone Walker records and learned all the arrangements and stuff, for about a month. And then the big meeting happened and it turned out that they were going to take Preston Hubbard from Scott and then I would join Scott's band, which I thought that's much better anyway, I don't have to play a bunch of blues all night long. I was already a swing and bopper by then. So that was a great thing but I think we only did six gigs before Scott left for New York and Chuck Riggs and I left for Widespread Depression up in Brattleboro, Vermont, where they were based at the time.

MR: Can you explain that? Widespread Depression?

PF: It's the name of a swing and jump band that was based out of Marlboro College. Chuck Riggs and I spent six months there basically saving some money so we could move to New York. And that's exactly what we did. And everyone in the band knew it. I remember the baritone player was being interviewed and he's going, "Yeah, they're using this band as a stepping stone."

MR: So I mean you'd had it in your head for a while at this point that you had to get to New York?

PF: Sure. Unquestionably. So much so that the first three weeks that I lived there I lived in the nurse's residence at Columbia Presbyterian Hospital in Port Washington.

MR: How did you manage that?

PF: I don't want to really go into detail about that. It was the only option I had to get my foot in the Manhattan door. So I did. I just think it's funny walking past the nurse's station with my bass every night, with the little like front desk they had, because it was like a dormitory.

MR: Well good story. You know, years later it makes for a good story.

PF: What the heck?

MR: Yeah, cracking the New York market, meeting people, getting out, playing jam sessions, hoping to play a gig and get a good recommendation?

PF: Well that happened because of Roy Eldridge, in Scott Hamilton's case. Scott preceded me into New York by about six months. He immediately had a gig at Michael's Pub with Hank Jones, Milt Hinton, himself, and I can't remember who the drummer was, it was somebody great. You know I can't even remember, it may have been Jo Jones or somebody, or Connie Kay or one of those.

MR: Grady Tate.

PF: Grady, possibly Grady. I can't remember who the drummer was, forgive me whoever it was, but so they warmed up to Scott immediately there, because he's playing music from their era and nobody has done this, everybody is going [scats] for twenty-five years before that. You know going one-four [scats]. These are my ways of making the over-academicized music sort of to turn it into an onomatopoeia if you will. See I can do it too, academia.

MR: Right.

PF: Yeah, just the ridiculousness of that over studied, under feeling sort of music. So they really embraced him because they hadn't heard anybody play a tenor saxophone without John Coltrane in mind, for like I said well probably fifteen, twenty years or better than that.

MR: Yeah, Coltrane really like, well he predominated the scene much as Parker did I guess.

PF: Even more so, because when Parker was alive they didn't have all the schools that cranked out a cookie cutterized viewpoint having to do with what's important in a various categorized box of music. Generally to academia they pick it apart and analyze it. If you do that, something with the most detail, it's going to be the most interesting, so something like Coltrane is the most interesting. I love Coltrane myself, except for the

festival that we're at now, is more traditional, and I can understand why that is. Because like language, jazz has a vocabulary and the vocabulary that's being spoken in a traditional situation like this is the vocabulary that is the basic words of the language. Now you can get very off on a tangent and get into all sorts of technical terms and that's what Coltrane would be doing, you know, taking the basic knowledge and taking it off and extrapolating it way out on one tangent or another, and saying, like reporting back what's out there. And I think that's great, I love that. I mean most of my really favorite artists are guys that have done that to some degree or other like Jimmy Rowles — stylistically way off on a tangent, musically correct but a little on the obtuse side, a little on the askew sort of thing. Getting back to my original point—

MR: Breaking into New York.

PF: Thank you. Breaking into New York, well Roy Eldridge was the other guy besides who I mentioned already that really embraced Scott and us. Because by then we were a sort of band and worked together. We worked at Jilly's, for Jilly Rizzo, you know Frank's friend.

MR: Don't know about that.

PF: Oh you don't know Jilly's? The club in New York. It was big in — how shall I say it — the powerful Italian people would congregate there. And it was a hangout of Frank's, Frank S. And those people loved to have a good time and back then throughout the '40s, '50s and '60s they hired good music a lot of them. They had good taste in music in my opinion. And we sort of fit into that crowd for a few minutes. That scene was sort of on the way down by the time we got there, '76, '77. But Jilly loved us and Frank came by a couple of times. It was gratifying to even get some attention from these people. And a lot of the people in New York would listen to these kind of people and if you were all right with them then you were okay, and then you might work at another place like Jimmy Weston's, and then you might work at blah, blah, blah. Not that those kind of affiliations amounted to anything really, but they were tolerant of us and we were tolerant of them and we were all very happy with the arrangement. I see it as — we could use a little more of that these days, in the politically correct, over bureaucracized, over administered scene that we have.

MR: Can I ask you what you would make on a typical night place like that?

PF: What I would make?

MR: Yeah.

PF: No that's confidential. No I'm just kidding. No back then? I remember making thirty-five bucks a night at Condon's. I don't remember what we made at the other places, seriously. I probably forgot it for a good reason. It was probably very easy to forget, not being very

MR: Was it a struggle then financially to make it, to stay alive?

PF: Oh, yeah. Sure. To be able to afford even a toilet of an apartment in Manhattan on jazz wages. These days a lot of guys get into doing a variety of things, playing electric, getting a symphony gig or a pops orchestra gig or anything like that. I never went that way, partly because I was ignorant that that kind of thing could be done. It just didn't make sense to me. I just wouldn't have fit in with that I guess. To me the way I look at it now, that's not out of the question now, as teaching and pontificating like I'm doing now is not completely out of the question as much as it seemed to be back then. Now I'm just a player.

MR: Well when did the first record date come about?

PF: That was something that Bob Wilber instigated for the Chiaroscuro label. He heard us play at Eddie Condon's and he was blown away that all these young guys — we were all under 25 then I guess — were playing this style music, so he got a date and he put — the original quartet, which was without piano, just Flory on guitar, Riggs on drums, myself and Hamilton, and with the addition of Wilber on soprano and alto and clarinet, but one at a time thankfully.

MR: Yeah. That would be a little Roland Kirky.

PF: Roland Kirky. Quirky and Kirky. So I wasn't terrifically — I guess at the time I thought it was okay, but these days, a typical seventies product with the direct pick-up sound into the board, and no microphone on the bass, direct off the guitar and no putting a mic on the amplifier or anything. It was just a cruddy recording. All the new technologies come out, like the pick-ups and the direct boxes and all this kind of stuff, so the techies figure they've got to use them. But now all the best recording were made before that, and now there are a number of people who have had the realization that we should go back there and see some high end and/or good recordings coming out with a more acoustical nature. Christian McBride for one, records mostly acoustically. I don't believe I've ever heard a record of his that had a direct pick-up sound on it, thank goodness.

MR: Bass players seem to be at the mercy of the sound people, more than anybody.

PF: Man, I've got stories you know. I went into this one session with Butch Miles, the drummer, and this was for Harry Lim, the Famous Door Records guy. And they had a young pony-tailed engineer there, and I had just gotten my new Underwood pick-up, which is good for live situations you know. At the time it seemed, I can play louder now, it's great. I get in there and we hook it up and we've got a direct sound on the thing and we do a little test track, and I said that's terrible. I mean the pick-up, it's a good signal and everything, but I hate the sound of it, could I please have a microphone. Maybe then you could mix the two at least, or if not just mix the direct out and leave the microphone

matter, don't you have one? I have one you can use mine." And the guy says, "No, no, no, no. That sound that you just got? That's what we want, we're going to stay with it.

MR: That's what WE want.

PF: Right. And I said, "Look, that's not my sound could we compromise?" I wanted to at least talk about it. He got very abrupt and said, "Look buddy, I'm the artist here and you guys are my tools." And at that point I realized what I was dealing with, that some guy in sound engineer school had propagandized this poor fellow into believing that, and — remember — I could just hear the guy in class saying — now remember, those artists are your tools. You're the real artist when it comes to the making of a recording.

MR: That's priceless. That is a classic statement. Wow.

PF: You can be a musician and not have any technical knowledge and know the serial numbers and model numbers of all the various different equipment, like an AV 20 and blah, blah, blah — an AKG, a 4756, and on from there — but the engineers may know all that and it's pretty useless data really when you get right down to it if you don't know what you're listening to, if you can't recognize a sound. It sounds simple, doesn't it?

MR: And what's appropriate for different musical situations, that a bass sound should be more authentic for this particular situation you were in than processed.

PF: Right. Well I'm not sure I understand the question.

MR: I don't think there was a question there.

PF: Yeah, okay. Well I can go off from there, because if it's an acoustic bass, it should be acoustic. Bing. The thing was made with this big piece of wood for a reason. That's so the wood moves the air, not so that it moves some little Piezo electric invaders that were stuck into the bridge to induce small currents to be amplified later, and then have a conical paper cone pushing air at an unwilling audience — unwitting and often unwilling audience. I don't see why you have to carry around all that wood if you're just going to pretend it's not there. If you want to heavily amplify your upright bass, get one of those stick things that has no body, that has no wood plates if you will, like the top of the bass, the part that moves and creates the sound, moves the air. If you don't have that and you're not using it, why not just admit defeat and play a stick.

MR: Play a stick. Did you ever play a stick?

PF: Yeah I have on a number of occasions. It's very, it's sort of like kissing through a screen door or something like that.

MR: Something like that.

PF: It's a little alien for me. It's different — I really don't like it because there's no shoulder here, so you never have to really go into thumb position. Thumb position is this thing, where you're putting the thumb on a string and fingering up above it. You don't have to

do that because there's no — you can just go up like this and it's different, a really a very different instrument.

MR: Isn't it hard — can you lean your body against it somehow?

PF: They have little struts and things that you can collapse for easy storage. It reminds me of an exercise machine you throw under your bed, this kind of thing. Bob Cranshaw has a good one though, that he had custom made for him, which is a bass — well it's a stick but it's got more of a cavity, like maybe a shoe box or slightly larger size piece of wood that's hollow. It has some resonance factor to it, so the bridge is not just sitting on a block of wood, it's something solid. So it moves a little bit. So it probably sounds better. But he's got it hinged — the neck — he's got it hinged so he can collapse the neck down, loosen the strings, loosen the thing on the neck, collapse it down and it all fits in a little duffel bag sized case that you can bring on an airplane or throw it in the overhead, or I guess probably just check it. It's the only one - he's got the only one.

MR: Wild. Does Sonny like it?

PF: I don't know. You'd have to ask him.

MR: So who were the other bass players around New York at that time that you would go out of your way to go see?

PF: To go see? Slam Stewart. One of my favorite nights of jazz I ever heard was Slam with Illinois Jacquet. It was a quartet setting at the Village Vanguard. And he didn't use any amp and he had gut strings on an old Kay bass with a little ribbon microphone out front. Sounded great. That was one of my favorite experiences. That and anywhere Milt Hinton was of course, Duvivier was still playing, George Mraz was on the scene and I used to go see him, I saw him with Zoot a couple of times. Basically though if you're a musician you don't get a whole lot of chances, you don't get enough chance to go out and hear the people that you'd like to. Because usually they're working the same night you are. I never run into bass players. I run into everybody else. On a festival like this I'll run into two other bass players. But in a normal day to day gigging situation, you hardly ever run into any. And drummers, same thing, because there's only one per gig.

MR: Where did you meet Milt?

PF: I met Milt at Michael's Pub in New York, I think it was that time when Scott was playing with them. It was one of his first gigs in New York and I came by and sat in and everything. I think that was the first time I met Milt. It just feels like I've known him forever at this point. That would have to be it, I'm sure that was it.

MR: Quite a guy.

PF: Don't get me started. He's ridiculous. I can't even imagine, the way I feel at 41, making it to his age and traipsing around the world with that big unwieldy thing, and playing the

no one else in history has been able to do, because I know I've tried to do it and I've showed other people — I show everybody that cares about it. I videotaped it and slowed it down, because it goes by too fast. He does a note, like a slap note and then a triplet slap, and then a note, triplet note [scats]. But he can do it — I saw him do it once when he was 85, like at a tempo like this [scats]. It boggles. Completely boggling. And plus he and Mona are just such sweethearts, just unbelievably great people.

MR: Some people make you feel good when you're around them.

PF: Oh, get Milt after the gig, some of his stories boy. It's like a history book just opening up. It's just amazing. Amazing character.

MR: How long did you stay in New York and did you get out doing road work with those particular — with Scott, you did some traveling?

PF: Well I got out with Scott quite a bit. I think we didn't work as much as a lot of people thought we did. I remember I think it was 1978, we'd been there a year and a half or so, where we had our best year on the road, I think we did 14 weeks on the road. And we never did as much as that again. Although we did anywhere from half to two thirds of that or something, for the next almost ten years. But everyone was relying more and more on freelancing in the New York area, and picking up whatever you could on the road with other people. I started working in duo situations with John Bunch. That tided me through a lot of potential poverty, and I also got a chance to learn all his stuff. It's the people that you're around. I keep trying to tell guys that are in school this, that the book learning and the theoretical knowledge and even the practicing and theoretical knowledge is great. But the thing that makes it what it is is the human element and if you want to be it you have to hang around it and you have to experience it, and it is the people that are doing it. So you've got to get out and hang out and get to know the people that are, like whoever it is that you look up to. In my case it was the people like Benny Goodman and Roy Eldridge and Maxine Sullivan and Vic Dickinson and Scott Hamilton and Ruby Braff, and Kenny Davern and Bob Wilber and those kind of people that were — some of them I didn't have knowledge of before I moved to town. But once I was on that scene, just from playing gigs with a lot of different people and using my own ears and my own judgment, yeah, I mean these were the people.

MR: What was it like to play behind Benny Goodman?

PF: Great. What could I tell you. I mean he always played good. You've heard all the stories about the ray and all the unthinking, careless things that he would do, the thoughtless things that he would do. And he acted very strange on any number of occasions. One time he came out, we were playing the big music hall in Philadelphia, Symphony Hall I believe it's called. Beautiful place. He comes out, the whole band is on stage, he walks

[whistles] almost like he's testing the acoustics or something. And the whole audience, including the band is sitting there scratching their heads going okay. And this goes on for like a minute and a half, two minutes, right at the beginning of the show. And then finally he just said "Hello. Good evening. It's so nice to be here. Where are we anyway?" But I viewed him as sort of a harmless sort of a talented idiot savant sort of. You know there's a lot of artists like that. They're brilliant artists, socially inept, just — they don't have a concept that there's even other people in the room, much less that they might be aware and might need to be communicated to, something basic like that. There's a category of artists like that. And I love to witness and absorb and consume their works.

MR: Yeah, and be part of it.

PF: But you don't really want to hang out with them you know? There's some that way and he was one of them. I mean to give you an idea, we were playing in L.A. one time, and we were staying at the Ambassador, and Jimmy Rowles was playing I guess it was a solo gig. It may have been Dante's, but I think it may have been somewhere else, I can't recall. It was in the early '80s. And a bunch of us, including Scott Hamilton, Warren Vache and I think probably Cal Collins, Connie Kay, those were the kind of people that were in the band at that time, John Bunch, we went over to catch Jimmy. And we sat down and then he finished his set and he came over and he goes, "Hey, what are all you guys doing in town?" And we go, "Oh we're here with Benny." And his response is, "Does he still sleep with it?" Meaning his clarinet. Because the guy related to the world through his clarinet, although a lot of people will say he was as sly as a fox. Strange, with a purpose. But I don't know if I buy that. I was up pretty close to it.

MR: He was pretty much, just strange.

PF: Yeah. I mean he did some things like the copier scam, you've heard that one.

MR: I've read it, but you can tell it.

PF: Well it's just basically Loren Schoenberg is the source of this story, because he was working for him. He was sort of a secretary and business manager. He would sit at the desk and answer the phone and run out to the drug store or whatever. And he asked Benny to copy some music and he needed some paper and this whole long story. Anyway Benny made sure that — there was three xerox copier machine outlet places there, with three different copiers in his apartment on 66th Street, because he's made an American Express card commercial, everybody knows who Benny Goodman is, right? So they need 60 copies. Benny says, "I need a demonstration, do you suppose you could make 20 copies of this?" And so he got his 60 copies out of the three machines, as samples. Then he looks at Loren and says, "Take care of him, will you," and he walked right out of the room, in other words, get rid of these guys.

PF: There's some funnier ones but I don't think I should get into them here.

MR: Well I was looking at your discography list. You've played in lots and lots of sessions. Do you have any personal favorites? I know the John Bunch duo record got some real nice press.

PF: That's one of my favorites. I mean I'd say that's my best work to date. It's hard. I don't like talking about my own work so much, except from a technical viewpoint. Artistically it's up to you. But I dig that one. I never was really happy with my sound until fairly recently. It's an interesting phenomenon.

MR: What do you like to see then when you go into a studio now? If you can tell the engineer exactly what you want, what's it going to be?

PF: I want a 60 year old Telefunken ribbon mic and that's it.

MR: I'm not sure a ribbon mic would—

PF: Like those big mics they used to use for like the vocalists, way back then. They have the fattest, warmest sound. There's a large surface area that vibrates, it's good for low frequencies, it's good for the human voice and it's good for the human voice-like qualities of string instruments.

MR: Sounds good. What prompted you to move to Florida?

PF: I got tired of the New York situation. Life there is, well it's not a highly habitable place, let's face it. It's dingy and dark and dank, and you need lots of stimulants just to get by, feeling like you're not a caged animal living in this little crystalline structure of boxes that the humans walk from box to box all day. And that just got to me after a while, I just figured there was a better of quality of life somewhere, and my parents already lived in Florida so I sort of did the stepping stone thing there again, stayed with them for about a year.

MR: You have a family now?

PF: Yeah.

MR: Did you have a family in New York?

PF: No, I didn't. I never could have afforded it. I didn't have a car, I didn't have a family, and nothing like that. I moved out to Fort Lee, New Jersey to be able to have a car, because I didn't have to pay for parking out there, I could park on the street out there. But you really have to have a garage in Manhattan. You can't park on the street, you're on a schedule just to park, because there's the alternate side, and it's free until 7 A.M. and then if you're not working that day you have to move your car to the other side of the street, it might take you three hours to find a spot. It's like a job. You're just better off paying your three, four, these days probably six, seven hundred dollars a month. Another rent, for your car space.

MR: I've often thought when we go to a gig in Utica, we can leave, whatever, 45 minutes before the gig and get there and park in front of the place usually. I've often wondered, man, what's it like to play a gig in Manhattan, if you've got gear? You've got a bass, and let's say you've got an amp. I mean, how do you do that?

PF: Bless you, Monk. I don't think anyone else has ever asked me a question like that. It's inconvenient to say the least, lugging an amp and a bass around. It'll make you crazy, because I mean I had dreams about my bass getting rained on, or kicked or stolen, or you know, all kinds of things. You become very physically welded to this object, and it's a severe pain, believe me, it really is, or can be.

MR: Did you ever do any of the session work in New York before you left?

PF: When you say session work?

MR: Well I guess that means a lot of different things — jingles or just pop dates.

PF: No I never did any of that. I did a Dixieland soundtrack for a race course commercial or something like that, that played on the local New York TV for a few weeks or months or something like that. And I did one thing with Warren Vache, the last time that Richard Burton and Elizabeth Taylor worked together was a show called "Private Lives." Noel Coward's "Private Lives." It was on Broadway for about three weeks in 1983. And we were supposed to be the pit band. It was like a six piece jazz and sort of chamber jazz little band. It reminded me of the kind of soundtracks they have in these PBS —English PBS, BBC-produced PBS shows, but without the violin. Like older, thirties kind of style. A lot of two-beat kind of things. Anyway, we recorded this thing, I guess it was sort of a trial to send the producer of the show — they sent us these tunes that they wanted to play. We arranged them and played them. They wound up using the tape rather than the live band. So I remember I got a check for half what our weekly salary would have been for eleven weeks I think it was. No it wasn't three weeks, it was eleven weeks that the show played. Either ten or eleven weeks. And that's the only time in my life I've ever gotten checks for work already done, that kind of thing. So that was real nice, but that's a whole other world. I don't know how we landed into that, Warren landed into that somehow.

MR: There's a whole, I'm sure, crowd of musicians who make their living that way, in the studio pits.

PF: Oh, by all means. They do financially better than us a lot of the time, just by virtue of the fact that it's steady work. It may not pay that great per night or whatever, but over the course of the year they're probably making more than we are because they're working five, six, seven, eight gigs a week. Like the guys that were in that show "Cats" and there are several other long running shows in New York with pit bands. These guys, they know their parts so well, they play it the same way every night, that they're reading magazines,

then the note comes — toot — you know, they're reading something and preparing something and then [scats] like that. And they go along with whatever they were doing, and Chapter 6, let's see, five, four, three, two, [scats]. And then that's it. It's funny to watch these guys. I don't envy them, because I'm mentally too restless. I mean I can't even handle a repeating bass line for more than about eight bars. That's agony for me, to have to repeat the same thing over and over. It's like talking to you like, like talking to you like, like talking to you like—

MR: That gets pretty boring.

PF: Like talking to you like this. I mean—

MR: You're on a loop.

PF: It's got to flow. Yeah, I know a lot of people that are on loops. You ever know someone on a real short loop? How long can you take that? You hang out with a person, and in ten minutes you start hearing the same stories over and over. That's a ten minute loop hard wired in.

MR: Have you ever had a point in your career thus far where you considered not doing what you do?

PF: Yeah, sure. Not like I didn't always know that I should be doing this, but different points where you capitulate to existence, and the raw inherently unjust way things are in life. I should be able to do this all the time, and make a whole pile of money, and have a whole bunch of friends, and like big TVs in my house and throw big parties and all this kind of stuff. But it doesn't work out that way and eventually you start thinking, well maybe what I should really do is get a power hose and spray down the inside of sauerkraut fermenting tanks in between season, and spray the mold off the wooden planks that comprise the walls of the tank.

MR: I have to ask, how do you even know such a thing exists?

PF: Well my dad had a sauerkraut factory in Phelps, New York.

MR: All right.

PF: Okay. That was the high school one. That's how I bought my first bass amp, my first Ampeg B15. I worked at my dad's factory for about 2-1/2 weeks and then I said that's it, because I was the boss' kid and they kept giving me all the hardest stuff to do. At least that's the way it looked to me, and I know I'm not wrong. Anyway that was just that one. Then in Boston I buffed floors in the Prudential Building. And I've sucked rugs, I've done a little of that, and —

MR: Well that kind of stuff helps keep things in perspective I think.

PF: It doesn't hurt, except emotionally. It doesn't hurt except your very soul.

MR: Only your soul.

PF: Yeah, only your soul, that's all, it only takes a big chunk out of that, never to be recaptured again. No I'm just exaggerating. But no it can, in the right circumstances, if you're the kind of personality who is already too full of himself and needs a good slap in the face, then that's a good way to get it. But I know a lot of musicians, not a lot, there's a certain cream of jazz people, natural players, that seem to avoid that through cunning or circumstances. And that's fine. I like that. I wish I could have done it.

MR: Let me ask you about these jazz parties for a moment. It's a pretty desirable thing to have in your plate of gigs?

PF: Oh, yeah, by all means. Strictly for the chance to meet people who comprise the jazz audience, that's one thing, but the main thing is the quality of the musicians. You come to a thing like this, and you know that everyone that you're going to be playing with is at a certain level, because you think about the axiom that a band is only as good as its worst player, which I believe to be true, given that being an accurate axiom, the lowest level of musicianship here is very high so you are never in a situation where you just can't get off the ground. The kind of things that happen on your own local scene wherever you are and you're working with people you never even met or a lot of times don't even have the same kinds of records in your collection. I mean I did a gig with a Brazilian singer not too long ago, and we couldn't communicate — even tune titles were very hard to get straight between his Portuguese and my English. And we settled on a whole bunch of Jobim songs, and that was fine, but he knew a whole bunch of other stuff that I just had to play by ear. I just had to go by — that's a one chord, a six chord, a four chord and then the three chord. You have to default to just like technical ideas rather than — I don't know their culture that good. I'm not steeped in that culture. I'm not trying to be an exponent of that. So now when he's back on my turf I take charge, we play some blues or a bebop tune or something, and he would play second fiddle.

MR: Is there a live music scene where you live in Florida of any extent?

PF: Yeah, it's getting better too. I think the main reason is about a year ago, maybe a little over a year ago, a guy by the name of Bruce Scott started a magazine, like one of those small booklet-sized magazines, styled after the *Hot House*, in New York. It's a listing. It's a place where all the listings can appear, and the clubs, and record companies, and whoever else in the music business, whether it be artists or big companies, whatever, can advertise whatever it is. Advertise a concert, advertise a record, advertise promotion for something. And it's got a couple of articles and a whole bunch of listings and a bunch of ads. And because of that, now it's possible to see, I mean the South Florida scene is spread out in three counties, Dade, Broward and Palm Beach. So between just north of Palm Beach and south of Miami that's a big area. So it's hard to — you might be aware

and fractured, but now, to somebody coming to that area, a tourist coming to that area can get this one book and see, this is happening in South Beach and this is happening in Ft. Lauderdale, and this is happening in Palm Beach County. And it's sort of something like to keep track of the music scene as a whole, taking the music scene as a whole. Because in my opinion the problem with music is just like the same problem that we have politically and everything now with everything splitting off into — like cable TV — instead of having three channels, three ideologies, now we have twenty seven thousand and we have forty seven different music categories. And that's what I like — the thing is called *Heat Beat*, the thing that's styled after the *Hot House*, it's call the *Heat Beat*. And it contains all the listings for south Florida. And it's just nice to see it all in one place. It gives you an idea that there is a scene there. And now with all the different clubs and stuff sort of competing for attention in the *Heat Beat*, it gives it a forum. It gives the whole scene, as one whole scene, a forum to like check each other out — and you can just imagine — well their ad was — and we're going to do bigger than them next month, and that kind of thing. So I think it's healthy for the scene.

MR: What other good musicians are down in your area? I know Ira Sullivan's down there.

PF: Ira Sullivan, Duffy Jackson, Eddie Higgins, Eric Alison, Pete Minger — now you've got me on the spot.

MR: Well that's okay. Did you ever do that gig at the Bread of Life? You know that place?

PF: Yeah. I did that a couple of times. I did it once with Pete Minger and Eddie Higgins, yeah.

MR: We were down there one time and we went there and saw Ira Sullivan.

PF: It's gone you know.

MR: It's gone now?

PF: Yeah. The owner, his name is Richie Gerber, he is Howard Stern's cousin, whoop-de-do. He's an amateur tenor player and always had an interest in music and started having music at this health food restaurant he had. Then he moved to a bigger location which was the big Bread of Life where they just had like a natural food supermarket, and in one little area where you could maybe eat some of the stuff you had just bought, they had a small stage and an upright piano. And it just made for a very strange scene musically, because like Eddie Higgins said, you're right in the middle of a chorus and you're just about ready to reach the climax and you hear, "Price check on aisle three, price check." Like that. And that can sort of kill the momentum of music that might be happening at that particular time. But these are the kinds of things that the politically correct, very psychologically correctly and nicely appropriate sort of mental attitude that you should have these days, would enable you to accept.

PF: Well, it has ever been thus I'm sure. But it really separates the people that are trying to learn something day to day, and those who are floating on something, resting on something, their laurels, the status quo or something else, or their little paychecks. And that's just one of my sociologically astute observations, that's all.

MR: Is there a racial inequity in the jazz scene today?

PF: No. And I'll explain myself.

MR: Please do.

PF: The jazz scene taken as a total, you've got some white racists and you've got some black racists. So it all adds up to zero, right? It's like the expanding universe you know. It all adds up to zero. There's as much going out that way as there is going this way, you add them up, they cancel out. But no, in all seriousness, jazz and the jazz viewpoint, the jazz perspective, is the one perspective, historically speaking now, from the early part of the century on up to now, that I've seen, has been the one area where discipline or world, jazz world if you will, that has actually really broken down any racial barriers. Now you may have legislation that claims to have done this and social situations that have claimed to have done this, and there are individuals of course that intermarry and this kind of thing and create little zebra children that are running around and controlling the airwaves now because nobody objects to them because they're in between. But it's silly and funny, it's an interesting thing to watch, and I'm sure very politically unpopular for me to say so, but no, I would say that there's not, only because it cancels itself out, if you were to add it up. You could have total racism — you could have fifty percent racism on this side, of course it's a useless argument. Yeah there's some racism but I don't want to pay any attention to it, because it's all, it's a moot point. How small can your perspective be to even, it's like the whole Monica Lewinsky thing. You know? Are you really that interested in that that you're going to spend all that — think of the money which has been generated between advertising, newspeople's salaries and camera crews and microwave transmitters.

MR: And lawyers.

PF: All the gas that's been burned up getting to the scene of the latest person who said something in a room with other people there. I heard a great thing on NPR last week. A reporter did a story about the Monica Lewinsky thing from the perspective that she turned everyone into fifth graders. And say well Bill said that Monica didn't do this thing, and Monica said that she got a phone call from so-and-so that said that Paula did, and she didn't like it, and this kind of — and they went through the whole story. And then Bill said this and then Kenneth Starr said no you can't do that. Then he said I have proof that Monica said that Paula didn't do — and it fit beautifully, just how utterly insane the

whole thing is, and I hope the whole world laughs at us because we're incredibly stupid to pay any attention to it, like we are to racism. Thank you very much.

MR: Okay. Good answer. I understand that you're getting into the school system down where you live and talk about jazz a little bit?

PF: Yeah, let me give you a little background. About a year or so ago I started getting calls for these gigs by this small organization called the South Florida Jazz and Swing Society, based in Delray Beach, which is just north of Boca Raton where I live. Now there's a whole bunch of retired people, if you look at that area demographically, there's a whole bunch of older folks, so you'd think that the swing/jazz demographic would be there. Sure enough, it is. There is an AM radio station there that plays swing and big band hits, and Scott Hamilton and Tony Bennett and Rosemary Clooney and that kind of stuff. So anyway, this thing started out as a record club. These guys would meet as record collectors and play records for each other and I understand it was twelve guys and then it was fifteen guys, and then it was eight guys, and then it was four guys, and then the last few months it was three guys, and one of the guys out of the three guys said this isn't working, let's change our operating basis here and let's start having some live performances. So they did, and they organized themself up to the best of their ability which I hate to say now, in retrospect, wasn't much because they didn't know they were a corporation, they didn't know they had to pay taxes. Of course now that we are an organization, largely because of the efforts of myself and my wife and our one friend Kurt Stern who's been instrumental in organizing all this, with of course the help of all these volunteers, we now have a jazz society, the South Florida Jazz and Swing, based in Delray Beach/Boca, Boca/Delray, the Boca Raton, Delray Beach area, that boasts of 580 members and those are couples. Each membership is for two people so you do the math, and it was probably 50 people last year at this time, or 12-13 months ago it was probably 40 or 50 people. And my wife and I, she's doing the administration, I'm doing the booking, and I'm artistic director and I'm the program committee and all this kind of stuff. So it's been an interesting experience for me to be on a board of directors and booking things for an organization, and playing with many of them but not all of them, and we do ten concerts a year and so far we've had people like Tommy Flanagan, Allen Vache, Johnny Varro's coming next month, we're getting Dick Hyman, we had Paul Cohen's big band, Paul Cohen is a lead trumpet player that used to play with Basie, Dorsey, Shaw, you name it. Etcetera, etcetera.

MR: I think the artists probably like having a musician in the role of doing some of the booking you know.

PF: Who likes it?

PF: Yeah, yeah. And I'm finding out that that generally is not the case with these jazz societies. I don't know how many there are in the U.S. now, maybe sixty or something, I'm not sure of that number. But it seems to me that very few of them have an actual practicing workaday musician making any of the booking considerations, which is interesting. I mean I've got to hand it to this guy Kurt Stern that organized this thing to put me in that position. Because my immediate position was like that of a union organizer. We've got to get these musicians some more money here. This is ridiculous. And it turned me into a Jimmy Hoffa or something for the musicians, which is a little strange, you know, seeing myself in that role. But it needed to happen, I mean the budgets were so low on the initial shows, I called them the 500 Club. That's for the whole band.

MR: Oh. What are we going to do for this? Yeah.

PF: Well anyway, they finally gave me a chance to lead a group and I did a Benny Goodman alumnus band where I put the guys I knew that had ever worked with Benny together and we did some Goodman music, and about 425 people showed up, which was a lot, maybe twice as good as we thought. And I'm going, wait a minute, the economics of this just aren't working out. Everyone in the band is not doing well enough here. So this guy Kurt said well why don't you join the board and you'll be the Program Committee guy and help make the decisions about — at least you'll have a voice. And pretty much I just went ahead and booked everything, then they couldn't say anything. They couldn't say anything about it, and one guy said well how come so-and-so's making so much more than so-and-so? And I said well 'cause you weren't at the last meeting. Usual political tactics like that. So I'm finding out how these kind of organizations run, and having some sort of community responsibility. I've been thrust into a position, willingly, of being put in a position where people want to influence me now. They say hey, don't you think we should add a guitar to that one. It gets pretty — I say no, no, it's music, remember? The charter says it's to promote jazz, to promote music. We're not just having more instruments. It musically has to be right. So far, I've often thought that this consumer market that we have and the way advertisers appeal to consumers is very condescending and insulting. So I just take the attitude that whether it's true or not, your audience can tell the difference, and so you better have your own finely tuned ear, you know, attuned to the music, the concept that you have of what's going to happen on the stage that month, and that you shouldn't let — as artists, you're better off with one viewpoint making that decision than you are with a committee viewpoint. Because the committee is going to just take the original — there won't be any original idea left by the time it gets chopped up and all. Everybody has to add their own little alteration to it. That kind of a

organization was not democratic. He was a monarch. They all respected the living daylights out of him, and that's the only reason that worked.

MR: Did you mention to me you'd recorded some of your own material recently?

PF: Within the last couple of years, yeah. I did I think seven originals out of twelve on this record I produced. And I wish I'd had a little more money to get a little better sound quality, but I'm funny that way. I'm very happy with it as far as at least having created myself an opportunity to do some writing and get some good musicians to play it — good lesser known musicians except for Duffy Jackson who was the drummer on it. Do you have a copy? I'll give you one.

MR: I would love to have one for our archive actually.

PF: Good. All right.

MR: And you're on tonight, two or three times?

PF: Once, maybe twice if Jay Leonhart insists.

MR: And you've got to leave for home tomorrow?

PF: I'm leaving for home, I've got a concert with Dick Hyman, we've got a rehearsal with him Tuesday morning at ten o'clock, so I have to leave tomorrow to be able to make it there somewhere in the middle of the night, this is on the west coast to Florida, and probably get six or seven hours of sleep and get up and start rehearsing.

MR: Yeah. Well it probably will be a good one with Dick Hyman.

PF: Yeah. It's an interesting little thing. We have a repertory orchestra. There's another jazz society in the Fort Lauderdale area called the Gold Coast Jazz Society that used to be booked by a very capable woman named Lee Amley who has since passed away. And their board is a board. They can't seem to decide what their actual thrust is, whether it's music or — well I haven't been that — I used to advise them on some things, but I've been too busy on this other one now. Anyway we're doing a concert over there with Dick and there's a guitar player down in south Florida by the name of Simon Saults who organized a — it's either a seven or eight piece group depending on whether we have a baritone sax or not, to do repertory material, jazz repertory, all the old Louis Armstrong things. When Dick is the pianist — we started out as a local group sponsored by the Gold Coast Jazz Society, so we had the unwieldy name of the Gold Coast Jazz Society Repertory Ensemble Orchestra, or something like that. Anyway I call it the Rep Work — a repertory orchestra. We do old stuff, historical jazz, and I'll play "Jack the Bear" the first bass solo from Jimmy Blanton with Duke, and I do a piece called "Trigger Fantasy" with them which was written by Trigger Alpert — he lives in Punta Gorda Florida now I think — sorry, Trigger, if that's not right — a piece that Dick arranged in the sixties for a Riverside record session under Trigger's name. There's a whole funny story that goes —

do that with him and they do a trumpet feature that Chris LaBarbara, a very excellent trumpet player over there, he's like Mister Repertory, he can imitate anybody. I mean he can do Harry James, he can do Louis, and he can do Roy Eldridge very well, and you name it. And it's an interesting thing. So then we add Dick in there, Dick comes out and does all his little stride things, the Jelly Rollisms, and I mean Dick is the living embodiment of the Encyclopedia of Jazz at his fingertips. I mean there is nobody that has more of that kind of knowledge than Dick Hyman, and can also play it. So that's always a lot of fun.

MR: Well I want to thank you for joining us here. Anything I haven't asked you about that you'd like to throw in there on your own?

PF: I can't really say that — I thought we were going to go a little bit more into history — I guess you have my basic history about going to New York and all that stuff, and then pretty much I left New York for Florida, I guess that was eight years ago, and since then I've been trying to be able to live in Florida and have my arms reach out further into the environment rather than, in New York, you don't need a very long arm, there's people real close.

MR: So you have to travel quite a bit to get out and get the work.

PF: Yeah. But that's okay. Florida is pretty flat and boring. I like looking at the hills and stuff here.

MR: Yeah. A different change of scenery.

PF: Florida, especially in the summer, can be brutal.

MR: Do you get overseas?

PF: Yeah. I've been doing Europe two or three times a year, either with Bob Wilber, or I went over with Frank Vignola, the guitarist, he did a little Django group there a little over a year ago, and who else — John Coliani, the pianist did a trio with Duffy Jackson, and the three of us. That was funny. That was a funny experience, I mean just being on the road with Duffy was something right there.

MR: I'll bet.

PF: Very hilarious cats.

MR: You know his father was here yesterday.

PF: First time I met him. I've known Duffy for years, and I just saw Chubby for the first day yesterday. I wish he could have hung out a little longer, it would have been nice.

MR: Yeah. Well the state of jazz for you is pretty productive I think for the most part.

PF: The state of jazz for me?

MR: Your involvement in jazz seems to be in a fairly healthy state. Can I say that?

PF: Yeah. I like that idea. I'm in agreement with that idea. I have all sorts of delusions of

give you some time before I leave will at least give you a hint, a very slight hint of one of the ways I'd like to take it. But I need some kind of firmer foundation beneath me to be able to do something like that, like a very rich backer type of person.

MR: Well if we use Milt Hinton for a judge, you have another forty years or so where you can—

PF: Can you believe that he was 85 when he had his first record out under his own name on a major label?

MR: Oh, man.

PF: 85 before Columbia gave him a date. Now that's one way to look at that. You could look at it as he made a zillion other records, but he neither asked nor planned on being the leader, so it's all how you look at it I guess. I'm sure he doesn't have any complaints.

MR: Right.

PF: I will say though that I am very grateful for the opportunity that I have coming up in July, at the 92nd Street Y, you know those concerts every July for a week or two. Dick Hyman is the musical director of the concert series at the 92nd Street Y in Manhattan, and he's doing a tribute to Milt this year on one of the nights. And he's going to have a piece written by Milt called "The Judge and the Jury." I've heard it by two titles: "The Judge Meets the Section," and "The Judge Meets the Jury." And on that Columbia release, "Laughing at Life," it's called "The Judge and the Jury." And we're going to do that piece and I'm going to get the Milt Hinton part.

MR: Get out. That's great.

PF: Yeah. Because of the slapping involved.

MR: Which I heard you do the other night.

PF: Yeah. And he listed, did he say Jay Leonhart and Jack Lesberg and Ron Carter and Rufus Reid are going to be the other bass players. So that's going to be a great honor.

MR: I guess so.

PF: Pay tribute to Milt.

MR: Absolutely.

PF: Now I've got to run home and learn the piece. I hope you have good editing capabilities.

MR: Well thanks for your time. I appreciate it.

PF: All right. Thanks, Monk.